

Eyewitness Trap Classroom Run Kit

TOK Cognitive Science Activity Bank • Knowledge and the Knower • 15-20 min

Category	Knowledge and the Knower	Time	15-20 min
Difficulty	Easy	ID	eyewitness-trap

Big idea: Memory is reconstructive, not photographic.

One-Minute Teacher Brief

Students see that memory is often reconstruction rather than playback.

Student Prompt

Inspect Eyewitness Trap Stimulus A. Record one first claim, the evidence you used, your confidence, and what would make you revise.

Concrete Stimulus Packet

Eyewitness Trap Stimulus A	Student-facing stimulus 1: A busy classroom image followed by questions about colours, positions, and text. Before discussing, write what you noticed, what you inferred, and how confident you are.	Students inspect this exact card first and commit to a claim before hearing anyone else.
Eyewitness Trap Stimulus B	Student-facing stimulus 2: A short silent hallway scene with one misleading follow-up question. Before discussing, write what you noticed, what you inferred, and how confident you are.	Use this for comparison, a second round, or a partner challenge.
Eyewitness Trap Reveal / Twist	Student-facing stimulus 3: A confidence-versus-accuracy table for memory claims. Before discussing, write what you noticed, what you inferred, and how confident you are.	Teacher reveal: connect the changed response to the big idea — Memory is reconstructive, not photographic.

Actual Lesson Questions

#	Question for students	Teacher key / cue
1	After inspecting Eyewitness Trap Stimulus A, what is your first knowledge claim?	Teacher cue: look for a clear claim, not just a description.
2	Which exact detail from Eyewitness Trap Stimulus A did you use as evidence?	Teacher cue: students should name visible words, data, source features, method features, or contextual clues.
3	What did you infer beyond the evidence?	Teacher cue: this is where assumptions, framing, models, or perspective usually appear.
4	How confident are you: 50%, 60%, 70%, 80%, 90%, or 100%?	Teacher cue: confidence is data for the debrief, not a grade.
5	What missing information would most improve the knowledge claim?	Teacher cue: push for method, source, context, comparison, or definitions.
6	When should memory be trusted as evidence?	Teacher cue: students should move from the classroom example to a general TOK issue.

Student Task

Use the stimulus cards to complete the observation/inference/evidence/confidence grid, then answer one TOK knowledge question connected to Knowledge and the Knower.

Teacher Key / Reveal

The key move is not the “right answer”; it is the moment students see how memory is reconstructive, not photographic.

- Strong response: separates observation from inference.
- Strong response: names a method, source, model, language choice, context, or perspective.
- Strong response: revises confidence when new evidence or a new criterion appears.
- Weak response: gives only opinion or says “it depends” without criteria.

Student Instructions

- Work silently for the first response so you can notice your own starting point.
- Record one knowledge claim, the evidence behind it, and your confidence level.
- After the reveal or comparison, update your claim in a different colour or column.
- Use the debrief to answer: When should memory be trusted as evidence?

Setup Checklist

- Prepare a starter stimulus using: A busy classroom image followed by questions about colours, positions, and text.
- Print or project the student response grid before the activity begins.
- Plan a private first-response moment before any group discussion.

Example Stimuli or Materials

- A busy classroom image followed by questions about colours, positions, and text.
- A short silent hallway scene with one misleading follow-up question.
- A confidence-versus-accuracy table for memory claims.

Resources To Use

- Resource pack: <resources/eyewitness-trap/index.html>
- Card deck CSV: <resources/eyewitness-trap/cards.csv>
- Visual prompt: <resources/eyewitness-trap/visual-prompt.svg>
- Printable student worksheet with observation, inference, evidence, and confidence columns.
- Teacher notes with setup checklist, sample facilitation language, misconceptions, and assessment look-fors.
- Classroom run kit with prompt cards, example stimuli, and debrief moves.
- PowerPoint deck with a student-facing sequence for running the activity.

Run Sequence

1. Show a busy image for 10 seconds.
2. Remove it and ask factual questions: colours, objects, positions, text, number of people.
3. Ask students to rate their confidence in each answer.
4. Reveal the image and compare accuracy with confidence.

Debrief Moves

- Knowledge question: When should memory be trusted as evidence?
- Why can sincere testimony still be unreliable?
- How might leading questions change remembered knowledge?

Teacher Quick Script

- Write your first judgement before we discuss it; the first answer is useful evidence.
- Separate what you noticed from what you inferred.
- What would make this knowledge claim more reliable?

Exit Ticket

- One thing I first treated as evidence was...
- My confidence changed because...
- A better knowledge question I can now ask is...